



Story Header



by SavantGuarde

Chapter Forty-Two

• 4.42.1 •

Atonement

01



TITUS

An uncountable span of solace graces the two of us. Days fade together seamlessly in this severed timeline. She continues to teach me everything she can, and I listen to every word, because I've never stopped to really hear her like this before. And maybe I've never stopped to hear anyone.

We don't have to call out the day when it arrives. We can both feel it. The only arguments we've had were about how I was going to do it, and even now, we continue to reach an impasse.

"It will be quick either way. But there's no way I can ask you to do that," I tell her.

"Aren't you afraid to die? And to do it to yourself, Titus . . . Gods above, how long has it been?"

"It's been a long time. And yeah, I guess I am afraid. I haven't slept easy the last couple nights—" though the sleep I did get was a hundred times better than when I first got here.

"Then let me do it. Please, it will be merciful, and you won't have to worry. You won't feel a thing."

"I can't put that on you. You have to live on here, Ellie, and I refuse to let you carry that weight — I love you too much to know that you'll suffer. And we won't be able to forgive ourselves on either side of it."

"But can you really do it?" She asks.

"I'll get over it," I say. I know she senses that hesitation in my voice, as if I'm asking for her to convince me otherwise, but I just can't let that come through. "My head hits and I'm done for. Just let me do it alone, I don't want you to witness this, no matter what horrible things you've been through . . ."

"I refuse," she says. "I still need to tell you that secret — what you have to do when you're up there in the Afterlife."

"You can tell me now, right?"

"You'll refuse to leave if I tell you. I have to make sure you go back, don't you remember? You made me swear I'd never let you get too comfortable or refuse your mission."

"That was so long ago," I say. "Unbelievable how long we've been here. It only feels like yesterday."

"And you've prepared yourself in every possible way you can. I know you're ready. You know you're ready."

Our words are just idle chatter. This is the first time here it's ever felt like a waste. I think about all she's done for me, and all I've been able to do for her.

"We'll turn to stone if we hesitate." Just a little longer, I want to say. I can see she feels the same, and so in that pulse of raw emotion, I concede.

I approach her, pulling her in for the last hug, the last time I'll feel her grown strength before she's just a child again, forgetting all of this except the love she's felt all this time.

"I'll let you do it," I tell her.

She begins to weep, and I feel her wet tears fall on my shoulders. I put my hand behind her head and tuck her in tighter, as if all the heat of my body in this moment could keep her warm for the rest of her life here.

"Thank you," she says. "It's the last act of love I can give to you."

It's the first time I've ever thought about what I'm leaving behind. "Where will you bury me? At the old house? Here in the Backwoods?"

"You'll be ash," she says. "You might blow away on the winds, too fine to capture a handful, but what's left is how you touched my soul, and that is forever."

"Will I see you in the end? When I free myself from this thread — will we meet again? In the reservoir? Will it join all these realities?"

"Let's make a promise to wait until we find each other," she says. "We'll jump together. We'll be born again!"

"I promise," I tell her.

Our time is short. I can feel how much I'm overstaying my welcome when purpose lies on the other side of this thread.

"What is your mission?" She asks.

"To get to the Afterlife," I say.

The amethyst begins to surge.

"How will you get there?"

"By rallying my closest allies."

"What will you pay?" Ellie asks, as I feel myself disintegrate.

"Whatever cost within free will," I say, as a comfortable warmth fills my body. "Of myself and all the others."

She sobs. "And to what end will you go?"

"One continuous push," I say. "Not to die by intention, but only by circumstance!"

"You're ready, Titus." The painless dissolution of my body decays my fingers to ash as I try to reach for her one last time. "You have one mission above all: one final act of love and mercy." Every part of me that remains is lighter than air, floating away as timeless firebrands, off to spark change in another life she'll never witness.

With all my lingering consciousness focused on the last surviving sense of sight, I read her lips as she speaks: a single demand of two words.